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SHEER GRIT ENABLED PARALYMPIAN AND JAVELIN THROWER **SUMIT ANTIL** TO BAG GOLD AT THE ASIAN PARA GAMES IN HANGZHOU LAST MONTH

At the Asian Para Games in Hangzhou in October, Sumit Antil was far from his best. A bulging disc in the back had been causing him trouble for a few months and he knew he had to preserve his body during the competition. "Since the leg with which I block is an artificial limb, the entire load goes to the back and creates a lot of stress on it. It's an old injury and we've been working on it, but I had to ensure that I don't aggravate it during competition," he says.

Antil needed just three throws to pick up gold in the F64 category. And with his third throw of 73.29 metres, the 25-year-old had rewritten his own world record (70.83m) that he managed at the World Para Athletics Championships in Paris in July. "I don't have a count as such, but I may have broken my own record for the 8th or 9th time. Though my target was to attain the 72-73 metre mark, I know it could have been a lot better," says Antil.

It's the sign of a rapidly improving athlete. Four years ago, Antil first broke the world record with a throw of 61.32 metres. At the Tokyo Paralympics in 2021, he smashed it on three occasions to eventually take gold with 68.55 metres. Today, he is the only para athlete in his category to have gone past the 70m mark.

"Of course, the target is always gold. But I always feel that I want to get better than what I was yesterday. This is the motivation to keep pushing my limits," he says.

At the Sports Authority



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